Chapter 1.

PRESENTING A WORLD VIEW

Calculations, Culture and Clarity

Three years ago, in my earlier book *The India Way: Strategies for an Uncertain World*, I had urged that 'this is a time for us to engage America, manage China, cultivate Europe, reassure Russia, bring Japan into play, draw neighbours in, extend the neighbourhood, and expand traditional constituencies of support'.[1] In the period that has passed, much of this has advanced but, obviously, not equally on all fronts. Some have progressed smoothly; others have been more complicated than expected. In the meantime, the world itself has witnessed deeper transformation. The challenges of a global order in transition have been magnified by the back-to-back impact of the Covid pandemic, the Ukraine conflict and the fighting in West Asia.

There is no question that this has now become a much tougher world. For India specifically, the going has been far from easy. Many of the larger concerns have impacted it directly. The changed posture of China on the border, in particular, is a major factor in its strategic calculus. But a determined leadership and a supportive society are helping it to navigate this turbulent era. Rising powers seek stability most of all; India must plan to rise amidst serious unpredictability.

International relations for the last quarter of the century have been dominated by five phenomena: globalization, rebalancing, multipolarity, impact of technology and the games that nations have always played. Globalization, the most fundamental of them, will only intensify, even though its earlier model of creating dependencies has come under growing challenge. It has led to rebalancing the relative weight of players in the world order. That initially unfolded economically, but its political and cultural facets are now making themselves felt. As it proceeds, rebalancing, in turn, will create multipolarity. A new lot of more consequential powers